

THE DATA MISMATCH CHECKLIST

Confirm you're comparing the same thing before deciding which number is "wrong."

SYSTEM A: 1,248. SYSTEM B: 1,231.

"Which one is wrong?"

Maybe neither. Different numbers often come from different definitions, timing or populations — not a broken system.

1 CONFIRM THE METRIC

"Trades" isn't a shared definition yet.

2 CONFIRM THE TIME WINDOW

Same day can mean three different things to three systems.

3 CONFIRM THE POPULATION

Market, region, client, status — same slice of the world?

4 CONFIRM THE SOURCE

Live database, cache or scheduled report — freshness explains gaps.

5 CHECK THE FILTERS

A forgotten filter resolves more mismatches than anything else.

6 CHECK DUPLICATES & GAPS

Sometimes the higher number is the wrong one, not the lower.

7 SAMPLE BEFORE YOU SCALE

Trace 5-10 mismatches by hand before touching all 100,000 rows.

8 CLASSIFY THE ROOT CAUSE

Data, definition, timing, processing, reporting or requirement.

DATA MISMATCH INVESTIGATION CHECKLIST

- | | |
|--|---|
| ☐ Same metric | ☐ Same business definition |
| ☐ Same date | ☐ Same timezone |
| ☐ Same population | ☐ Same filters |
| ☐ Same status | ☐ Same source |
| ☐ Same identifiers | ☐ Duplicate check done |
| ☐ Missing-record check done | ☐ Small sample reconciled |
| ☐ Root cause classified | ☐ Business decision recorded |

REMEMBER

Neither number was "wrong." They were never counting the same thing.

Most mismatches resolve into a one-sentence answer once someone traces a handful of records instead of arguing about the totals.